

Q. Why do you post pictures online?

A. Honestly, I just like the attention and praise for it. I like to share my voyeuristic exploits with friends.

Q. Why pictures of women shopping, hanging clothes, standing at a bus stop? These are just regular women!

A. Have you watched TV recently? All the most popular shows are based in reality. We want to see real women, in everyday scenarios, and admire them. Pornography is so fake and so passé that most people now prefer to see regular women in revealing street clothes, rather than pornstars in action!

Q. But without their permission? Most of the responses are hardly anything that women will find flattering...

A. I can't help how people express themselves. I see beauty in real women, and I take pictures of them to remember it. If someone else cannot control his vocabulary, that's his problem. At least I have the courtesy to blur out faces most of the time, to prevent these women from being recognised. Most others don't.

What's sad is that he's right! Most of the other people posting pictures didn't blur out the faces of the women they'd secretly photographed. In three days of research, this writer saw over 2,000 pictures of women from around India, posted on forums or blogs that deal with voyeurism—and in addition, at least 500 video clips that could be classified as adult material, all of them involving real people being filmed without their knowledge. The settings were as varied as bathrooms / public toilets, hotel rooms, and even those shot at home, with or without the subject's consent.



Genius has a Web camera that looks like a stuffed toy—can be used as a concealed camera?

Reality Means You

It's true. Whether you consider voyeurs sexual predators or just irritants, the reality is that they're just waiting for a chance to catch you in a compromised situation. By reading what voyeurs say online, it's obvious that there is no stereotype: it's easy to tell that some of them are just teenagers with overcharged hormones (generally using IM-speak in posts), while others seem to be very well-educated adults, fluent in language and technology. So what this means is that your friend, neighbour, boss, employee, beautician, servant, etc., could be voyeurs, and you'd never know.

With millions of women being exploited by voyeurs worldwide, how do you stop this happening to your friends or family members?

Should we stop going outside our houses? Make sure we dress (and do everything else as well) in the dark? We know we cannot. So how do we prevent being exploited like this?

The easiest way to prevent being embarrassed is by understanding how voyeurs work, and what they use to spy on you.

The Tools Of The Trade

Most of the tools used by voyeurs are video capture devices. From regular webcams to miniature spy cameras, it's all available online and at select stores in your city.

Our first stop had to be ebay.in. Here we found quite a few "spy" cameras on sale for less than Rs 800! Obviously not any great quality, but probably good enough to get a grainy picture—though *any* sort of picture is bad enough for a victim. For the voyeur with the desire to film in complete darkness, there are products such as the "Night vision wireless colour security camera (2.4 GHz)". Because it's wireless, this camera can be set up anywhere, while the voyeur sits nearby (up to 1,000 feet away) and enjoys the show. It's also easy to record the video and audio stream.

Ironically, most of the devices that are a potential threat to your privacy are sold as security devices! Take the pin-hole cameras that are widely available. Unlike other cameras, which are quite easy to spot, pin-hole cameras are very hard to detect, as they literally need just a pin hole to look through. You get wireless versions that can be hidden inside anything, like teddy bears, small boxes, behind / inside walls, false ceilings, etc. You also get pen cameras, which are hidden in plain sight. Then there are the alarm clock cameras and the smoke detector cameras, which are very obviously made for spying purposes.

None of them are overly expensive, either, ranging in price from Rs 1,000 to Rs 40,000. Obviously, the more expensive spy cameras offer better resolutions, with lower lighting requirements—and are more concealable. Audio is another addition to the more expensive models.

Of course, sometimes the actual technology isn't anything special, like when installing a camera behind a one-way mirror! You could even install a bulky movie camera or camcorder behind a one-way mirror—if there's space available. There are various ways to check for one-way mirrors—shutting off all the lights and

Situations To Avoid

- ❑ When holidaying with your family, make sure you stay at a trusted hotel. Smaller guesthouses and rooms on rent might compromise your privacy. This doesn't mean that all smaller establishments are unsafe, or that all large hotels are safe—it's just the law of averages!
- ❑ Avoid shooting yourself or your family in compromising situations. Most of the voyeur content online is "leaked" content that was shot with the knowledge of the subjects! Want to make that honeymoon special? Try a candlelight dinner instead of making an A-rated home movie!
- ❑ Don't store sensitive content (of yourselves, your family, or your friends) on your PC or mobile phone. Your PC might be used by your friends who could stumble across this content, and your mobile phone could be stolen.
- ❑ Cyber cafés are another problem. If you're storing personal and/or explicit content in your e-mail account, accessing that account from a public place such as a cyber café is a bad idea. If someone has installed a keylogger on that machine, they can get access to your e-mail account, and as a result, all your personal data. Blocking your credit card is easy, but living with the embarrassment of being caught with your pants down is not.